

FUTURE SKILLS SERIES

FREE

AI Literacy • Lesson 1 of 6

THE LITERAL GENIE LESSON

How to Talk to AI

AI grants what you SAID,
not what you MEANT.

Grades 6–8

45-min lesson

No prep • No devices needed



STUDENT SESSION

Cursed Wish Repair Shop



Name: _____ Class: _____ Date: _____

The genie's one rule: it grants exactly what you SAY — never what you MEANT. A **cursed wish** is one the genie can twist. A **genie-proof** wish can't be twisted. Genie-proof every wish with all three **P.R.O.** parts:

- **P — Purpose:** what you want + who it's for
- **R — Requirements:** the rules (at least 2) — length, tone, format, what to include or leave out
- **O — Output:** what the finished answer should look like (a list? a table? a paragraph?)



CURSED WISH #1 — AMARA'S SPACE POSTER

Amara's science poster is due Friday. She typed *"tell me about space"* — and got 40 pages on the history of NASA. Rewrite her wish so the genie can't get it wrong. Use P, R and O:



CURSED WISH #2 — MATEO'S HEADPHONE FUND

Mateo gets \$15 a week and wants \$120 headphones. He typed *"help me save money"* — the genie answered: "Stop buying things." Rewrite his wish. Use P, R and O:



CURSED WISH #3 — YUKI'S HERO STORY

Yuki wants an anime-style story for the class magazine. She typed *"make a story about a hero"* — the genie wrote: "Once there was a hero. The end." Rewrite her wish. Use P, R and O:

THE LITERAL GENIE LESSON • LESSON 1 OF 6

How to Talk to AI



45 minutes, no prep. The hook: AI is a literal genie — it grants what you SAID, not what you MEANT. Students learn both human jobs in every AI task: the prompt and the check. Stands alone.

AT A GLANCE

TIME	MATERIALS	TECH NEEDED	PREP
45 min	Cursed Wish Repair Shop worksheet (2 pages, 1 per student; typeable PDF included) • Slides (optional) • board for P.R.O. • Teacher Guide (Scoring Guidance, P.R.O. sentence starters) • pens	None — runs fully unplugged. Optional: a projector for the slides; one AI tool (ChatGPT, Claude or Gemini) on your screen for the Showcase.	Print worksheets (and Teacher Guide p.3 if you use the Support/ELL sentence starters). That's it.

OBJECTIVES

ISTE 1.5.c

ISTE 1.3.b

CCSS ELA W.6.4

- Show how a vague prompt lets the genie choose (and why that produces a worse answer). (Exit Ticket #1, part two)
- Apply **P.R.O.** (Purpose, Requirements, Output) to write a clear prompt. (Wish repairs 1–3; Exit Ticket #1)
- Evaluate a sample AI answer: find the checkable claim and where to check it. (Exit Ticket #2)

WARM-UP — THE WORST GENIE EVER (8 MIN)

You are a genie who grants wishes *exactly as worded*. Takes 3–4 wishes and ruin every one, cheerfully:

"I wish I was rich." → "Done. Your name is now rich."
 "I wish for a million dollars." → "Granted: one million dollars, in play money."
 "I wish school was over." → "Granted: The school building is now over... there."

Then ask: "**Whose fault was that — the genie's, or the wish?**" **Bridge:** "AI works like that genie. It doesn't know what you MEANT — it only knows what you SAID. Every AI job goes human, AI, human: you start it with the wish, the genie does the middle, and you check what comes back. Today you get good at the human parts."

What if a wish is inappropriate? Don't play it: "The genie doesn't grant that one. Next wish." Nobody volunteers? Wish first yourself: "I wish for a snack" → "Granted: one grain of rice."

Transition: "So how do you write a wish a genie can't twist? Lawyers figured this out a long time ago."

DIRECT INSTRUCTION — PARTS OF A GENIE-PROOF WISH (10 MIN)

Lawyers make contracts genie-proof with clauses. Strong prompts have three parts — write **P.R.O.** on the board as you go:

P — Purpose. What you want + who it's for. "Explain photosynthesis to a 6th grader" beats "explain photosynthesis."

R — Requirements. The rules: length, tone, format, include / leave out. This is what stops the twist.

O — Output. What should the finished answer look like? A list? A paragraph? A table? A plan?

Watch one get fixed — build the repair on the board, naming each part as you add it. **Cursed wish:** "help with my history essay" → **Genie-proof P.R.O. prompt:** "I'm writing a 7th grade history essay on the printing press. Give me 3 thesis statements and 2 pieces of evidence for each, as a bullet list. Don't write it for me." With devices: run it live.

◆ THE AI-HONESTY DISCUSSION (USE ANYTIME IT COMES UP)

Q: "Is using AI cheating?" — One sentence settles it: *AI is your editor, not your ghostwriter*. Feedback, brainstorming, checking understanding = editor. Handing in its work with your name on it = ghostwriter, and a wish you never earned. Ask: "What did YOU make?"

Q: "Is the AI always right?" — No. It predicts likely words; it can be confidently wrong ("hallucinate") — a trickster genie. Rule of thumb: anything that's a checkable fact (dates, numbers, names, quotes) gets checked against a real source before you use it.

Q: "Will AI take all the jobs?" — The honest answer: nobody knows, and say so. So far the clearest cases are tasks inside jobs, not whole jobs — nobody can promise the final count. A person who can direct an AI clearly and check what it hands back likely has an edge — and that is today's lesson.

FULL STANDARDS TEXT

- **ISTE 1.5.c** — Students break problems into component parts, extract key information, and develop descriptive models to understand complex systems or facilitate problem-solving. *Taught: P.R.O. instruction (a prompt broken into Purpose / Requirements / Output). Assessed: the three wish repairs (worksheet p.1) and Exit Ticket #1, scored with the Scoring Guidance above.*
- **ISTE 1.3.b** — Students evaluate the accuracy, perspective, credibility, and relevance of information, media, data or other resources. *Taught: the trickster rule that opens the Exit Ticket block and the "Is the AI always right?" discussion. Assessed: Exit Ticket #2 — students evaluate a printed sample AI answer, find the checkable claim and name where they would verify.*
- **CCSS ELA W.6.4** — Produce clear and coherent writing in which the development, organization, and style are appropriate to task, purpose, and audience. (Grade-specific expectations for writing types are defined in standards 1-3 above.) *Taught: the Purpose part (task + audience) and the Requirements part (style, length, tone). Assessed: wish repairs 1–3 + Exit Ticket #1.*

SUPPORT 6: P.R.O. SENTENCE STARTERS

P: "I am a ____ grader working on _____. I want ____ for _____."

R: "Keep it ____ (length). Use a ____ tone. Include _____. Do NOT _____."

O: "Give me the answer as a ____ (list / table / paragraph / steps)."

Support students may repair two wishes instead of three. ELL students may draft in their strongest language first, then translate — the starters double as language frames.

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